

Chapter 101-1 - Honesty

The two of them walked one after the other along the riverbank. The moonlight was bright, casting the green grass on the ground in cold emerald hues. It wasn't until the town appeared to merge with the darkness that they stopped.

Ning Fuyi discovered that beneath her feet was a patch of flower clusters - unnamed pale white wildflowers dotted among the grass like dim stars fallen from the sky.

Fine sweat emerged in her palms. She had stood on the long street for half a day, as if reviewing all the events of this lifetime in her mind.

Initially, she only wanted to protect her through this life's tribulation, ensuring she wouldn't suffer too much hardship. But she had underestimated the obsessive desire for Chu Qingqiu in her heart. This desire had consumed her for thirty years - how could it be easily suppressed?

So she still couldn't help but scheme to get close to her, feigning injury and pain. But that kiss just now was absolutely not her intention. When Su Mo, despite her own terror, fought desperately to protect her, in that moment, her mind seemed to be swept into a whirlpool of dizziness.

"Would you like to speak first?" Ning Fuyi's eyes, with her back to the moonlight, were dark as the night sky.

Su Mo nodded and lowered her head to place down the birdcage. She faced the moon directly, her veil already removed. Her beautiful face competed with the moonlight for radiance, her birthmark alluring like something unfurling in the wind.

"When I was young, I fell gravely ill. My parents found an enlightened Taoist master who cast a divination for me. He said that although I could extend my life with medicinal pills, medicine cannot change one's fate. Therefore, no matter how much my life is extended, it won't exceed twenty-three years." Su Mo peacefully and slowly moved her fingers, narrating as if speaking of someone else's destiny.

Ning Fuyi clasped her hands behind her back, wiping the sweat from her palms on her clothing.

"And this year, I am in my twenty-second year in this world."

Although Ning Fuyi had heard the rumors early on, she hadn't expected there to be only one year remaining. Her eye sockets immediately heated up, unable to bear looking at Su Mo's smiling face any longer.

"I originally thought I would spend the remainder of my life alone as usual, finding some remote place on the mountain to dig a grave and lie down, thus clearing my sins." Su Mo tried to make her expression lighter.

"But after you appeared, I realized that ghosts aren't so terrifying after all, and that there are people who don't mind my yin-evil¹ constitution. I also don't reject your approach. By your side, I feel very safe."

"Therefore, although you transgressed during the day, I'm not angry." The more Su Mo spoke, the redder her face became, like ripe fruit even under the moonlight.

"But I must tell you clearly - if that Taoist didn't deceive me, then I only have one year of life left. I can't give you anything. If you choose to leave, I won't blame you. I also won't be sad for too long. I'll still live as I always have."

"Yiyi." She opened her mouth to awkwardly say her name, biting her lips until they showed blood, carefully reaching out to grasp her sleeve.

The feeling of weight came through the clothing. Ning Fuyi suddenly widened her eyes, so shocked she was nearly paralyzed, unable to speak for a long while.

She was accustomed to Chu Qingqiu's silent profundity, so she had never imagined that Su Mo would be so frank - so frank that it made her face flush and heart race, losing her composure first.

"Su Mo." It took Ning Fuyi a long time to speak, her voice somewhat ethereal, as if she had made an enormous resolution.

"I already don't mind how much longer you have to live. Whether long or short, I'll accompany you through it. If you don't want me before you, I'll also secretly follow by your side."

"But since you're willing to be open and honest, I also don't want to deceive you. I've long had feelings for you - from decades ago, or perhaps from hundreds of years ago."

"But at that time, you were the moon in the sky, and I was Chang'e² on earth who couldn't steal the elixir of immortality. Every time I gazed at the moon, I yearned but couldn't obtain. So I buried those feelings in my heart. Over time, they became an obsession."

Ning Fuyi smiled self-deprecatingly, her smile appearing broken in Su Mo's eyes. She stepped back, distancing herself from Su Mo, lowering her head to avoid looking into Su Mo's clean eyes.

"Su Mo, I don't know if you believe in past and present lives. The previous you didn't like me - in fact, very early on, you despised me like sticky mud under your feet. I hated you greatly. I hated why you wouldn't love me."

Ning Fuyi clasped her hands behind her back, her left hand pinching her right until it hurt. She smiled sarcastically: "Perhaps you think I'm talking nonsense."

Su Mo stood frozen in place, her hand unconsciously releasing Ning Fuyi. They didn't speak again for a long time. Ning Fuyi didn't know what she was thinking, while Su Mo used a very, very long time trying to digest what Ning Fuyi had said.

The corners of her eyes had turned red at some point, gleaming silver in the moonlight. She raised her hand again, her fingertips trembling slightly: "You're not lying?"

"Why tell me this?"

"I initially never thought of telling you. I wanted to keep it hidden forever." Ning Fuyi's hair was blown by the wind, the moonlight veiling her in a layer of cool, thin gauze. "But just now I stood by the river for half a day, remembering many past events, which made me change my mind."

"I know the feeling of being kept in the dark by someone you trust, so I don't want to deceive you. I also don't want to be a villain, taking advantage when you've lost everything."

As she spoke, she looked toward Su Mo. The other seemed unable to accept such reality, her back stiff, her expression dazed.

Ning Fuyi smiled.

"I'll take you back." Ning Fuyi pretended to dismiss all her emotions, turning to walk toward the foot of the mountain. However, she heard the sound of flowers and grass being trampled and bent behind her. Then, two snake-like soft arms climbed up her waist, carefully embracing her from behind.

Ning Fuyi's heartbeat skipped a beat. When it resumed, it pounded as if all seas and eight desolations³ could hear it.

So hugging someone doesn't feel scary and isn't something to reject, Su Mo thought absentmindedly. Then she circled around Ning Fuyi, turning to face her, raising her eyes to enter her line of sight, watching the woman's cheeks flush red because of her.

"I'll only ask you one question - did you mistake me for someone else?" Su Mo's gaze was resolute, her gestures clean and beautiful. "Are you certain that person was me, not someone else?"

Now it was Ning Fuyi's turn to be stunned. She shook her head, then nodded.

Su Mo seemed somewhat relieved, gently tapping her fingers: "Then it's good. I know I like you, and you're willing to stay by my side. Nothing could be better."

"I believe in past and present lives. That Taoist said I committed too many sins in my previous life, so in this life I must atone." Su Mo didn't show the anger or confusion Ning Fuyi had imagined, but spoke with a calm expression, struggling to "say" the words.

"You said the previous me didn't like you, but when I first saw your eyes..." She tapped her right hand against where her heart was, making a thumping motion.

Clearly, from the very first meeting, her heart had been pounding.

Ning Fuyi looked down in disbelief, then raised her head. Her peach blossom eyes, with their back to the moonlight, still sparkled like a constellation of stars.

Seeing Ning Fuyi frozen, Su Mo's starry eyes turned, and she suddenly raised her hand again: "If what you said isn't false, could you tell me what sins I committed in my previous life?"

Ning Fuyi's heart was filled with mixed feelings - confusion, excitement, and sorrow. She covered her lips and shook her head.

"You committed no sins. You were the most beloved by all living beings, the best person."

"Really?" Su Mo's eyes became even more brilliant. She suddenly felt relaxed all over, hesitating for a moment before placing her hand in Ning Fuyi's palm.

Though her hand had scars and was rough, when those rough scars brushed across her palm, Ning Fuyi almost wanted to cry out.

She grasped it in return with wild joy, lowering her head to embrace the person in her arms. The woman's body, shorter than in her previous life, was delicate and soft, filling her heart and lungs like cotton.

"Really."

Su Mo also returned Ning Fuyi's embrace. The other's body was soft and burning hot. Being caressed once on the back made her feel numb all over, her body softening somewhat.

"Scoundrel, scoundrel, scoundrel..." At this moment, the startled parrot struggled out of its cage, circling around the two of them and chattering noisily, breaking the tender moment.

Su Mo's ears turned red as if blood would drip from them. She hurriedly released Ning Fuyi, standing in the moonlight with her hands at her sides, letting the night wind cool the heat throughout her body.

Ning Fuyi's racing heart finally calmed. She raised her hand and caught the parrot, looking down to see the golden yellow parrot with round eyes struggling in her hand. Its frantic appearance looked strangely familiar.

"It's called Bird⁴. It was a chick that landed at our door the day I was born. My father felt it was fated to be with me, so he raised it." Su Mo said with flushed cheeks.

Surprise flashed in Ning Fuyi's eyes, then she smiled and stuffed the bird back into its cage.

Then she said joyfully: "Let's go back."

Footnotes:

1. **Yin-evil constitution (阴邪之身)** - A body type in Chinese metaphysics believed to be naturally prone to attracting negative spiritual energy and ghosts.
2. **Chang'e (嫦娥)** - The Chinese goddess of the moon who stole the elixir of immortality and flew to the moon, leaving her husband behind. Used here as a metaphor for someone who desires but cannot obtain their beloved.
3. **All seas and eight desolations (四海八荒)** - A Chinese expression meaning "everywhere in the world" or "the entire universe," emphasizing vastness.
4. **Bird (鸟儿)** - A simple, affectionate name Su Mo gave to her parrot, showing her innocent and straightforward nature.